Extended Essay

Title: An exploration into the use of unconventional materials

Subject: Visual Arts

Research Question: How did the use of unconventional materials in the works of Magdalena Abakanowicz and Eva Hesse influence their processes to express meaning?

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Table Of Contents

Table Of Contents **1**

Introduction **2**

Magdalena Abaknaowicz **4**
Overview of Art 5
Androgyne III 8

Eva Hesse **11**
Overview of art 12
Contingent 14

Conclusion **16**

Works Cited **18**
Works Cited (Figures) 18
Works Cited (Websites) 19
Works Cited (Books) 22
Works Cited (Videos) 23

Introduction

“The history of art is the story of humanity's creative expression and visualization of the world around them” (Wang, 2022). In response to changing values, in the last century, art has evolved in unpredictable directions. Artists like Marcel Duchamp altered people's perceptions of art to break down the boundaries between works of art and everyday objects (Lebel, 2019). The 20th century became one of the most dynamic periods for art, as well as opened a gateway for artists to express themselves with unprecedented freedom (Lebel, 2019).

Duchamp was born in 1887 and was a French painter who later in his career developed the idea of “readymades”, a term he originated to describe works based on manufactured objects (MarcadÃ, 2008). “Art is produced by a succession of individuals expressing themselves; it is not a question of progress” (Duchamp, 1946). Many viewers and curators took offense at Duchamp's work, considering it to be an assault on traditional art. Duchamp spoke of the role of readymade objects as allowing him to find freedom from the “trap” of developing a particular style or taste (MarcadÃ, 2008). Duchamp influenced many of his contemporaries, as well as and future artists, who began experimenting with their expression by communicating distraught and often angry reactions to societal upheaval, notably the horrors of WWI, by rejecting the established standards of producing art and often shocking viewers. This movement was founded in Europe in 1916, by a Zurich-based German writer, Hugo Ball, who labeled it the Dada Movement. His ideas started as a writer’s rebellion, but later crossed boundaries into various art forms, spread throughout Europe, and eventually influenced artists in many other countries. “The Dada art movement was anti-war, anti-establishment, and anti-bourgeois” (Randall, 2022).

It evolved into one of the most influential art movements in modern history .“Dada was an art movement formed during the First World War… in reaction to the horrors and folly of the war. The art, poetry and performance produced by Dada artists is often satirical and nonsensical in nature” (Tate)

Artists started moving away from the accepted forms of subject matter, skills and materials to find unique paths of expression, with a major shift from traditional practices and views on art and creativity (Tate). In particular, artists began to consider and explore materials that were previously unknown in the art world, challenging and ultimately rejecting traditional materials. This new direction evolved over time and took years to evolve, as society often resisted the repudiation of traditional skills and materials. “It was a way to get out of a state of mind—to avoid being influenced by one’s immediate environment, or by the past: to get away from clichés—to get free” Duchamp states in, addressing the DaDa movement.

I was intrigued by the use of unconventional materials when experimenting with my own personal practice, in IB visual arts. I found myself uninterested in paints and brushes, and was always attracted to more unusual materials. This is when I became interested in specific artists and their works, and discovered two female artists with whom I particularly identified. It was inspiring to follow how they chose their materials, and also why, and the meanings behind these choices. This led me to my research question: “How did the use of unconventional materials in the works of Magdalena Abakanowicz and Eva Hesse influence their processes to express meaning?” My interest in art and particular fascination with the style of art between the world wars, as well as the influences of these artists going forward, was an opportunity to express in

this essay an exploration of how the use of their materials contributed meaning and encouraged others to experiment.

Over the duration of my visual arts class, especially throughout the DP program, I've learned that materials are a large component of the creative process and impact the sensory result of the viewer. It intrigues me that the choice of creative materials and ideas express different stories and meanings, unique to the artist who is sharing their vision. A majority of the research within this essay comes from books about both artists which include conversations, notes, sketches, and journal interviews, as well as their personal writings.

The essay is broken down into the two artists followed by an overview of their general artworks, and then an analysis of a specific artwork. The overview allowed me to find patterns in their more general works, as well as patterns in their unconventional material usage, and the analysis of the specific art pieces allowed me to analyze the artist in more detail, breaking them down into their formal qualities.

Magdalena Abaknaowicz

Magdalena Abakanowicz was born into a Polish noble family in 1930. She experienced WWII firsthand as she was nine when Germany invaded and occupied Poland. Already during this time she recalled a pull to create, she had an urge to touch and to collect materials which to her “embodied stories”.

“ When I was a child, objects were for me a bridge between myself and reality. Later I began to study at the Academy of Fine Arts in Warsaw; it was a very hard period of realistic socialism. My study was a disappointment. There were so many rules and prescriptions to follow, completely against my feelings and imagination. I realized how many trends and philosophies were around me in the world of art. And how much I didn't fit into any of these movements” (Dally (*W&C*), pg. 176, 2022) During her formal education, the traditional materials and techniques of art school were the basis of instruction. She soon eventually rebelled against the constraints to expression.

As an artist in post war Warsaw society, her choice of materials led her away from the study of fine arts, and she soon transferred from the fine arts department to the department of textiles, where she finished her studies (Kinnecome). After her studies, Abakanowicz fully devoted her time to weaving and served as the artistic director of the weaving factory at which she worked (Kinnecome). In the compendium of her writings and conversations, she speaks of how this was not because she was interested in weaving itself, but because the nature of the process allowed her to express her intentions without authoritative constraints. Her fine arts professors would correct her work and impose their opinions. She mentions *“....hating all the imposed philosophies… and people who know what art is, how it should look, and how it should be made”* (Dally, *(W&C)*, pg.191, 2022).. She rejected the idea that art is one thing, and not another.

Overview of Art

Early in her career, Abakanowicz was first recognized for her three-dimensional fiber sculptures, specifically her *Abakans,* seen in **figures 1 and 2,** which are enormous, roughly

hand-woven forms suspended for the ceiling which were unlike any traditional tapestry and was a major departure from the traditional 3D sculptural materials of bronze, marble, wood, etc. Though woven, they were not flat, and were decorative pieces to be hung on walls. Instead, these often 4-5 meter tall and 1-2 meter wide entities encouraged viewers to interact with them, by walking around and under them. Abakanowicz became a pioneer in alternate materials as well as a new kind of powerful expression in sculpture. They evoke nature in their earthiness, "The Abakans were a kind of bridge between me and the outside world. I could surround myself with them; I could create an atmosphere in which I somehow felt safe because they were my world; they were something between figurative and natural, like animals, like figures, while abstract, like geometric forms, but never to be definitively described " (Dally, *(W&C)*, pg.191, 2022).



Figure 1: **ABAKAN RED 1969**, sisal weaving on metal support 500 x 300 x 100 cm,Collection of the Museum Bellarive, Zürich



Figure 2: **BROWN ABAKANS** 1969/1972, sisal weaving, 300 x 300 x 350 cm

The most commonly used material in these first works is burlap, which is a strong natural fiber with a coarse texture, made from the jute plant. It originated in India but made its way to Europe

in the early 1700s. Becoming a staple material for many industries, it was used to create sacks that carried various produce, from coffee beans to potatoes, but gained in popularity in the 20th century when it was used to create the uniforms for German soldiers. It was an extremely common material, often used for weaving, but was not as common in the art world (fashinza, 2014).

Abakanowicz accumulated other materials from the garbage, such as gathering mattresses and old ship ropes. Her process included unraveling every thread, washing and dying it, and later hand weaving these into her works. She expressed "...the urgency to create - and to do"(Dally *(W&C)*, pg.159, 2022).and these materials, as unfamiliar and unpopular as they were, gave her what she needed. "I began to use old burlap sacks for my sculptures because they were the only material I could find that was truly typical of the environment around me. At the time, I could not speak about my reality using marble or bronze; they had an improper elegance in comparison to my everyday life. I have also used old pieces of wood in my work: These old materials have their own mysterious history, which I try to understand in order to add my own experiences to it (Dally *(W&C)*, pg.247, 2022).

It is difficult to describe a "style" within Abakanowicz's work, as she never adhered to one way of expressing herself. "When I feel I have arrived at something, I don't try to repeat this result. I try to find another solution" (Dally *(W&C)*, pg.42, 2022) she explained in an interview after an Abakan exhibition, when asked if an underlying idea will be present in her upcoming exhibitions. This spirit of exploration is characteristic of her art, with its changing styles, materials, and methods. It is evident that the process was her primary motivation, and that the

final product was secondary. However, the viewer is engaged with the end results of her works. “It was absolutely a conscious decision that, for an object such as my work, I must construct the materials from which I will make it like our skin is constructed. I wanted to make this skin for the created object …. the making of the skin allowed me to be responsible for everything in this object” (Dally, *(W&C)*, pg.191, 2022). This obsessiveness about her chosen materials reveals her insistence on full control of her expressive process, which contributes to the meaning of her works.

She often uses repetition of her 3D images, especially in her more anthropomorphic works, which can be viewed as figurative or abstract (in their hollowness which emphasizes light and shadow) depending on the angle of view. The Androgens are a good example of this repetition and light/shadow play, almost as if the “humanity disappears” before our eyes (an influence of her war years).

Androgyne III

This work by Magdalena Abakanowicz is called Androgyne III (***figure 3 & 4)***. The 3-dimensional art piece was created in 1985, in Poland and is a continuation of her work on figures, which she started in the mid-1970s (Ziemlańska, 2010). It measures 121.9 x 164.1 x 55.9 cm and is a mixed media predominantly made from wood, burlap, nails, string & resin(MET).

Androgyne III is a sculpture of the human form as a husk without arms, legs, or a head, sitting on a wooden rack.



Figure 3: Androgyne III, 1985, (**BACKVIEW**), 48 in. × 64 5/8 in. × 24 in. (121.9 × 164.1 × 55.9 cm), Burlap, resin, wood, nails, and string



Figure 4: Androgyne III, 1985, (**SIDE VIEW**), 48 in. × 64 5/8 in. × 24 in. (121.9 × 164.1 × 55.9 cm), Burlap, resin, wood, nails, and string

According to the MET the sculpture evokes a depiction of a soldier or a person who is missing their arms and legs, which could be a reference to the time in which Abakanowicz worked in the hospital during World War II. However, Abakanowicz has stated that all of her figurative pieces are "...about existence in general"(Dally, *(W&C)*, pg.189, 2022)

The piece was created by dipping burlap and string into resin, which she then pressed into a plaster mold, which had been cast from the body of a friend. These anatomical backs are cast from the same mold as those in some of her previous works (seen in ***figure 5***). The figures are hollow, repetitious, and are androgynous, as the gender characteristics are absent.



Figure 5: Magdalena Abakanowicz ,1976, 660 × 580 × 680 mm, Burlap and resin.

According to author Kinnecome from khan Academy, Abakanowicz wanted viewers to focus on the humanity of the figures by avoiding specific detail, such as gender and features. She wanted viewers to experience other details, such as the visible veins, scars, musculature, and wrinkled skin.There is an irony to depicting the human form without specific features and attributes, but the result is a universality of the concept of "humanity".

The use of burlap was very prominent in her artworks and was used in the making of the Androgyne series. While it provides texture to the figures, it also gives the artist the chance to reference and explore her symbolic meanings, such as the body, the earth, and natural forms, such as shells and cocoons. The burlap dipped in resin allowed her to create the creases, folds, and textures she envisioned to express the story of a skin, whether for a figurative piece, or as an abstract form. Though she rejected the formal constraints of traditional expression, she was a fine craftsman with highly developed, diverse skills.

As I mentioned, traditionally burlap was used as sacking for goods, due to its breathability and durability. In Abakanowicz's installations, the burlap depicts flesh and serves as a metaphor: a symbol of endurance, perseverance, and withstanding hardship and stress. Their hollowness suggests passivity(Battista, 2015).

Abakanowicz ties her personal history into her art in many aspects, but the most distinguishing characteristics of her sculptures are their ambiguity, which encourages multiple interpretations. Clearly, her intention of expression is dependent on her choice of very basic materials, which in themselves evoke a reaction.

“Abakanowicz’s creative use of fabrics such as the tough fiber derived from sisal (a member of the agave family) prefigured in some way the return to basic materials encouraged by Joseph Beuys and the Italian ‘Arte Povera’ style at the turn of the decade”(Sedia, 2010).

Eva Hesse

Eva Hesse was born in Hamburg in 1936 into a German-Jewish family during the rise of the Nazi regime. With the dangers of raising their children in Germany, Eva's parents escaped the regime and moved the family to New York in 1939, where she grew up. (National Gallery Australia, 2018). She was exposed to traumatic experiences at a very young age, including her grandparents being killed in Germany, her parents separating in a new country, and her mother taking her own life. She began studying design and art in 1952 and was later trained as a painter, but soon discovered that the parameters of painting did not address her expressive need. In her diaries, there are many instances between the years 1955-1959 where she states feeling stuck and not knowing how to start a painting, or just not having the motivation to finish her paintings, often expressing that she and the canvas did not understand each other (Hesse*(Diaries)*, p.115 2020). It soon became clear that she was searching for a kind of equilibrium by exploration of unconventional materials, and although she spent a majority of her professional career focused

on painting, which gained her recognition as an artist, these were only the beginning of who she would become in her short life.

Similar to Abakanowicz, Hesse often rejected the philosophies taught in the art schools, did not understand the assignments, and often felt "lost", which in turn affected her mental health. She felt as though her work was not good enough, and only when she began exploring different materials that she found her niche. It was after a visit to Dusseldorf in 1965 that she became interested in the German art scene, which at the time was dominated by abstract sculpture. After the trip, she returned home and began her experimentations with different materials, which ultimately led to her transformation from painting to sculpture.

Overview of art

In her early stages of sculpting, Hesse used more industrial materials, such as metal rods, and rubber tubes, creating art that included aspects of both two and three-dimensional qualities, such as being hung on a wall but spilling into the space, as seen in ***figure 6.*** These first works developed her understanding about what she wanted to express, and like Abakanowicz, she was a disciplined craftsman. "With this work, Hesse is really breaking down barriers and the traditional definition of painting and sculpture and she's combining them. She's creating an amalgam of both" (Donavan)



Figure 6: Ennead, Eva Hesse, 1966, Acrylic, papier-mâché, plastic, plywood, and string, Approximately 96 x 39 x 17 inches (243.8 x 99.1 x 43.2 cm)

In the early stages of her pivot to sculpture, paper mache was her preferred medium and was often used to create the base of the sculptures to which she would add elements like rope, as seen in ***figure 6***, which allowed her to work with the textures, and she developed a "dialogue" with these materials which was more intuitive than deliberate. "Her work emphasized the intuitive and self-reflective" (Musgrave, 2013).

It was only in 1966 that she began exploring latex, and her new focus on this material catalyzed her career. In works which demonstrate the development of her techniques with latex, she transformed this industrial material into a form of expression.

Many frustrations are noted in her diary about the way her art is aging, because the work deteriorates over time (Hesse, pg. 153 (*Diaries*), 2020). With time the chemical composition of latex breaks down, resulting in disintegration, however, in an interview posted by San Francisco Museum of Modern Art Hesse seemingly comes to terms with the impermanence of her work,"Life doesn't last, art doesn't last", Hesse says, accepting this as a positive element contributing to her aesthetic, rather than a liability. She loved the fluidity and neutral colors as well as the characteristic texture of latex(SF MoMa). Hesse describes the various subtleties of her chosen materials and textures as coarse, rough, translucent, consistent, and smooth. In a video analysis of one of her pieces (pictured in ***figure 7***)



Figure 7 : Aught , Eva Hesse,1968: : Latex, resin & Fiberglass

Michelle Barger mentions Hesse being fascinated by the way latex moved, starting as a liquid and soon hardening and changing. The transformation was part of her process and creation(Barger).

Contingent

This piece by Eva Hesse is called Contingent and was created in 1969(seen in ***Figure 8***). The components are all roughly human scale, varying between about two and three meters in height (DeFreston, 2014).

Contingent is made from eight vertical panels of cheesecloth, covered in latex and dipped in fiberglass, then suspended from the ceiling. They are not identical, but resemble each other. The piece is delicate and translucent, as if it is fading away. Light is diffused through the cloth parts and the installation changes depending on the light in the room, "...evoking tight formal groupings of different components and marshaling of forces, it is based on variability and uncertainty, much like her life…" (NationalGalleryofAustralia, 2018). She offers an experience instead of a conventional view, as the viewer is able to walk around and through the installation and see it from many different perspectives.



Figure 8: Contingent, Eva Hesse, 1968: fiberglass, liquid latex, cheesecloth

It is the last art piece Hesse created before she passed away from a

brain tumor later that year. The inherent uncertainty is contained in the materials. Tom Defreston writes that the work no longer exists, except in photographs: apparently it has disintegrated (DeFreston, 2014). In her diaries, she describes her pieces as "...ethereal, sensitive, and fragile", like the flesh of a body, which she explained was meant "...to portray the essential absurdity of life" (Pincus-Witten, 1971)- It is not only the material that shows these qualities but also the process, in which the artist puts all of her energy and self in a very intimate experience.
Hesse was associated with the international trend of what is generally referred to as MINIMALIST ART. Her art shared many characteristics of minimalism, in that there were many instances of repetition, as well as a neutral color palette. Her process was chaotic, but the end results were subtle, with the output being somewhat austere and neat.(Project Nord, 2019)

The Minimalist trend was emerging among artists and designers in several European countries, notably in Italy, where it was known as Arte Povera, and the FLUXUS group which was initiated in a New York gallery in 1962 by the Lithuanian-American artist George Maciunas. The FLUXUS trend became very influential in Germany. Hesse was in Germany for a 15-month long sojourn in the '60s.

"A central Fluxus tenet was to dismiss and mock the elitist world of 'high art' … along with Dada, Fluxus was one of the few art movements to use humor … Fluxus artists were serious about their desire to change the balance of power in the art world. Their irreverence for 'high art' had an impact on the perceived authority of the museum to determine what, and who, constituted 'art.' "(DiTolla, 2012) Hesse, too, rejected the idea that art is reserved for the elites of society, and her focus became centered on the expressive nature of unusual materials taken from the sphere of

industry, as a means of expression as contained within their textures, colors and limitations. Even their impermanence was part of the expression.

Conclusion

Both Abakanowicz and Hesse rejected the pressure and constraint of their formal training and their societies, as they each were compelled to search for greater expression by seeking unconventional materials. They struggled to break away from the strict definitions on what art must be, taking inspiration from artists such as Duchamp.

“Abakanowicz’s art has been autobiographical, influenced by her experiences growing up during WW2 and under the Soviet regime” (Yael) Abakanowicz was also rejecting the rigidly defined Soviet art of the time, which strongly influenced the arts in Poland at the time.

Hesse, whose family suffered under the Nazi regime, rejected the artistic opression of Nazi Germany by having the opportunity to seek freedom in the USA. In her journals, Hesse also mentions Mondrian and Duchamp as influences (Hesse,pg. 781*(Diaries)*, 2020). Minimalism was a great inspiration for Hesse - but she deviated from its rigid formality towards more ambiguous and softer forms.

Both artists found that three dimensional forms are essential to their expression. Abakanowicz moved away from drawing as her primary expression, and Hesse moved away from painting, in favor of sculpture. Texture became a primary focus and consideration for their practices. Abakanowicz utilized only natural materials, and Hesse was more open to incorporating synthetics such as fiber glass, plastic and synthetic resin, in addition to the natural products such

as cotton and latex. Both artists have written or spoken about *process* being an integral part of their expression: the materials themselves provided a "path" for the "journeys" of the two artists.

For both artists, the unconventionality of choice of materials left their objects open to interpretation. Their focus on materials as the primary creative componen echos in some ways the famous 1964 quote (referring to the communications technology of the time) by newscaster Marshall McLuhan: "The medium is the message" (McLuhan, 1964). The artists didn't "dictate" meaning to the viewer, and the materials themselves were an integral part of the "story" or subject, as opposed to the long-established norm of representational portrayal in academic art. Therefore the use of unconventional materials within the works of these two artist not only aided tremendously in expressing meaning through their outcomes but also paved a new way for artists and viewers, and their relationship to art.

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